

ON TECHNIQUE

The leitmotif

Richard Wagner sought to create operas that were unified dramas, rather than broken up into arias, choruses, and recitatives. Starting with *The Flying Dutchman*, which was composed in the early 1840s, he employed leitmotifs—recurring musical themes that are associated with specific characters or other elements of the drama.

This technique was fully developed by the time Wagner wrote the first operas of his Ring cycle in the 1850s. Leitmotifs such as the horn call representing the heroic Siegfried constantly recur and transform, weaving a continuous musical web that underlies the work's dramatic action.



JEAN DE RESZKE
IN THE ROLE OF
SIEGFRIED FROM
THE RING CYCLE

The youngest of nine children, Richard Wagner was born in Leipzig in 1813. His father died when he was a baby, after which